

The End State Is the Requirement

A Public Introduction to Zero Trust Outcome Architecture

Tommy Burke • 2026 • ~9 minute read

Most Zero Trust conversations start in the wrong place.

They start with tools.

Identity providers.

MFA.

PAM.

Microsegmentation.

DLP.

DRM.

SIEM.

SOAR.

Policy engines.

Automation.

AI.

Those tools may matter.

But tools are not Zero Trust.

Other conversations start with frameworks.

Pillars.

Capabilities.

Activities.

Maturity levels.

Implementation phases.

Roadmaps.

Those structures may also matter.

But frameworks are not Zero Trust either.

The real question is not whether an organization has purchased the right tools or completed the right activities.

The real question is:

Can the organization prove that the intended security condition exists?

That is the foundation of **Zero Trust Outcome Architecture**.

The activity is not the requirement.

The security condition is the requirement.

Activity Completion Is Not Outcome Achievement

In large organizations, especially government and defense environments, security work is often managed through activities.

Activities are useful.

They help assign work.

They help track progress.

They help organize teams.

They help brief leadership.

They help satisfy oversight requirements.

But activity completion can become dangerous when it is mistaken for security achievement.

An organization can complete an activity and still fail to produce the intended security condition.

It can deploy a tool without enforcing policy.

It can create an inventory without keeping it authoritative.

It can collect logs without producing risk intelligence.

It can implement segmentation without reducing meaningful lateral movement.

It can produce governance artifacts without improving operational security.

That is the checkbox fallacy.

The work was done.

The condition was not created.

Zero Trust fails in that gap.

The End State Reveals the Intent

The most important question in Zero Trust implementation is not:

What activity are we completing?

It is:

What end state is this activity supposed to create?

Activities describe work.

End states describe intended conditions.

That distinction matters.

If an activity exists to create an intended end state, then the end state becomes the key to understanding the activity.

The proper traceability chain is:

Strategic Outcome
↓
Zero Trust Outcome
↓
Required Condition
↓
Architectural Function
↓
Capability
↓
Activity
↓
Evidence

If that chain is intact, the activity has meaning.

If that chain breaks, the activity may become compliance theater.

The Hidden Architecture

When Zero Trust activities and intended end states are reverse-mapped, a deeper pattern emerges.

Underneath the pillars, capabilities, and activities, Zero Trust repeatedly asks the same operational questions:

- Who or what is involved?
- What is being requested?
- What do we know about the subject?
- What do we know about the object?
- What risk exists right now?
- What policy applies?
- What decision should be made?
- Where is that decision enforced?
- How do we know it worked?

- What changes if conditions change?

Those questions are the real architecture.

They collapse into three functional concepts:

Attribution

Authority

Authorization

The pillars organize the work.

The Three A's explain the work.

Attribution

Attribution answers:

Who or what is involved?

It establishes identity, ownership, source, state, provenance, classification, and context.

Attribution applies to:

- users
- devices
- applications
- workloads
- services
- data
- sessions
- events
- alerts
- logs
- flows

Without attribution, Zero Trust cannot function.

A system cannot evaluate what it cannot identify.

Bad attribution creates bad decisions.

Examples of attribution include:

- user inventory
- device inventory
- application inventory
- data cataloging

- identity federation
- credential issuance
- data tagging
- asset correlation
- log normalization

Attribution is the first layer of Zero Trust because everything else depends on knowing what is being evaluated.

Authority

Authority answers:

What does what we know mean?

Authority evaluates whether the known attributes, posture, behavior, risk, mission context, and policy relationships support the requested action.

Authority is not the same as entitlement.

An entitlement may say a user has a role.

Authority asks whether that role should still matter under current conditions.

Is the device compliant?

Is the user behavior normal?

Is the data sensitive?

Is the workload approved?

Is the vulnerability risk acceptable?

Is the request consistent with mission need?

Is the access pattern suspicious?

Authority turns information into decision-relevant meaning.

Examples of authority include:

- device posture
- user behavior analytics
- threat intelligence
- risk scoring
- security profiles
- data classification
- vulnerability status
- mission and task access profiles
- baseline behavior

- compliance state

Authority is where Zero Trust becomes dynamic.

Authorization

Authorization answers:

Should this action be allowed right now?

Authorization is the decision and enforcement layer.

It turns attribution and authority into operational action.

Authorization is not merely permission.

It is a decision made under specific conditions.

Examples of authorization include:

- conditional access
- privileged access management
- just-in-time access
- just-enough administration
- deny-by-default policy
- policy decision points
- policy enforcement points
- DLP enforcement
- DRM enforcement
- data access control
- macrosegmentation
- microsegmentation
- API-level enforcement
- dynamic policy updates

Authorization is where Zero Trust becomes real.

A policy that cannot be enforced is only documentation.

An access decision that does not change behavior is only theory.

The Operating Model

Zero Trust can be understood as an operating model:

Attribution

↓

Authority

↓

Authorization

↓

Evidence

↓

Reevaluation

First, identify who or what is involved.

Then determine what the known information means.

Then make and enforce a decision.

Then collect evidence that the decision occurred and worked.

Then reevaluate when conditions change.

That is Zero Trust in motion.

Reframing the Pillars

The traditional Zero Trust pillars are still useful.

But they are implementation domains.

The underlying function is different.

Identity creates trusted attribution for users and non-person entities.

Device capabilities establish whether devices are known, managed, compliant, and trustworthy.

Application capabilities determine whether workloads are known, secure, authorized, and trustworthy enough to participate in the environment.

Data capabilities describe, classify, tag, protect, and control access to data objects.

Network capabilities provide the enforcement fabric for policy boundaries and damage containment.

Automation capabilities make approved decisions and workflows repeatable at scale.

Visibility capabilities create the evidence layer that supports risk understanding, investigation, response, and reevaluation.

The pillars organize the work.

The Three A's explain the work.

The Replaceability Test

Once the end state is understood, a more mature question becomes possible:

Is this activity required because it is the only way to create the condition, or is it one prescribed implementation path?

This is the replaceability test.

If another implementation creates the same required condition and produces equivalent evidence, then the specific implementation may be replaceable.

That does not mean organizations can ignore formal requirements.

It means architects and assessors can have a better conversation about equivalency.

The right question becomes:

Can the implementation prove the same outcome?

That question shifts Zero Trust away from tool compliance and toward operational assurance.

Evidence Is the Difference

The strongest Zero Trust evidence is not a slide.

It is not a policy document.

It is not a status report.

The strongest evidence is operational behavior.

Can the environment show that unknown users are denied?

Can it show that unmanaged devices are blocked?

Can it show that privileged access is temporary, monitored, and justified?

Can it show that data tags affect access decisions?

Can it show that DLP policies detect or prevent exfiltration?

Can it show that segmentation limits lateral movement?

Can it show that risk signals change authorization decisions?

Can it show that access is reevaluated when conditions change?

That is the difference between activity completion and outcome assurance.

The Claim

Zero Trust is not achieved when activities are completed.

Zero Trust is achieved when required security conditions exist, operate, produce evidence, and adapt to changing risk.

The activity is not the requirement.

The security condition is the requirement.

The end state reveals the condition.

Evidence proves whether the condition exists.

*The activity is not the requirement.
The security condition is the requirement.
Evidence is how the condition proves itself.*

That is **Zero Trust Outcome Architecture**.

And that is how we move from compliance activity to operational assurance.

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"Asymmetric Precision"



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